



The Simpson Desert

Australia's most centrally located desert, where sand ranges from pink to deep red and forms the largest parallel dune system in the world

The Simpson Desert forms part of Australia's red center: the colloquial name for the Northern Territory's southern desert region that reflects the dominant color of its sands. Stretching south from the Northern Territory's famous outback town of Alice Springs to cross the border of South Australia, the Simpson covers an area of around 68,150 square miles (176,500 square km). It contains the largest parallel sand dune system on Earth. These dunes vary in height from 10 ft (3 m) in the western desert to 100 ft (30 m) on its eastern side, and can extend for 120 miles (200 km) or more.

A desert in bloom

Rainfall in the Simpson is low and irregular, averaging just 5 in (125 mm) annually. However, spinifex grass, shrubs, and acacia trees grow year round, joined by colorful wildflowers that bloom suddenly after a rare rain shower. Rainfall in nearby areas can also cause some parts of the Simpson to flood as inflowing rivers burst their banks. The resulting vegetation provides a haven for various animals, including the rare fat-tailed marsupial mouse. National parks and conservation areas have been set up in parts of the desert to ensure both flora and fauna are protected.



△ PLAINS DWELLER

The gibberbird's name reflects its main habitat—the gibber plains of Australian deserts, a type of desert pavement. It rarely flies, preferring to feed, nest, and roost on the ground.

